

Title: Otondo Diaries

Duration: 5 Minutes

SCENE 1: Anita's Home (Morning)

(Anita lounges on a plush sofa, wearing a silk robe, scrolling through her phone. A half-finished smoothie sits on the table beside her. Her parents, Mr. and Mrs. Oladipo, sit across from her, visibly tired of her complaints.)

Anita: (dramatically) "Why do I need NYSC? It's not like it'll help me get a job. Daddy, please! Just call someone and fix this for me!"

Father: (sternly) "Anita, enough! This isn't optional. You are going."

Mother: (calmly) "Sweetheart, three weeks won't kill you. It might even do you some good."

Anita: (rolling her eyes) "Good? In a place with no AC, no proper bathrooms, and worst of all—no WiFi? I'll die before the three weeks are over."

Father: "You've lived in comfort long enough. It's time you learned that life isn't always easy."

Anita: (throwing her head back dramatically) "This is child abuse! I'll tell the whole world!"

(Her parents exchange tired glances as Anita storms out of the room. Cut to the motor park.)

SCENE 2: Motor Park

(The motor park is chaotic, bustling with traders shouting, passengers haggling, and vehicles honking. Anita, dressed in ripped jeans and a designer top, struggles to drag her heavy box while shielding herself with a fancy umbrella. Her frustration is evident.)

Anita: (to herself) "This place smells like sweat and suya. What did I do to deserve this?"

(Aisha notices Anita struggling and approaches her with a friendly smile.)

Aisha: "Hello! NYSC, abi? You dey go Ede camp?"

Anita: (pausing, eyeing her) "Yes. Unfortunately. My parents are forcing me into this nightmare."

Aisha: (smiling warmly) "Relax small. Camp no go kill you. My twin sister was in this camp last batch, so she gave me all the gist."

Anita: (frowning) "You're lucky. I don't know anything, and I already hate it."

Aisha: "Don't worry. I'm Aisha. What's your name?"

Anita: (sighing) "Anita. I still don't know how I'm going to survive this."

Aisha: (laughing lightly) "You'll survive. If my sister survived it, we will too. Abi no be the same three weeks?"

(The bus they're boarding honks loudly. Aisha notices Anita struggling with her bag and steps in to help.)

Aisha: "Let me help you with this. Camp wahala never even start, and you don't even complain."

*(Background Character, a vendor): "Sister, buy gala o!"

(They both lift Anita's bag into the bus. The camera follows the bus through dusty roads as Anita complains about the heat and noise. Aisha listens patiently, occasionally laughing.)

SCENE 3: Hostel Arrival

(Anita drags her heavy designer box awkwardly across the rough, dusty path leading to the hostel. Corps members are unpacking, chatting, and trying to settle in. The sun beats down mercilessly.)

Anita: (looking around, horrified) "Is this really the place? It looks like a refugee camp!"

Aisha: "Welcome to camp o! Abi you think say na hotel dem book you? You go dey alright."

(They arrive at Anita's hostel. Aisha waves goodbye, smiling.)

Aisha: "My hostel no be this one. See you later, Anita!"

Anita: (calling after her) "You're leaving me alone?!"

(Background Character, a soldier near the hostel entrance): "Keep moving! No loitering here!"

(Anita walks into the noisy hostel, dragging her bag. Her bunkmate, Chidera, sits on the top bunk, eating a snack. She looks down at Anita, grinning.)

Chidera: "New girl! Welcome o. You look like you want to faint already."

Anita: (dropping her bag) "Yeah. This place is worse than I imagined."

Chidera: "You'll survive. Just don't go near the bathroom yet—it's not for the faint-hearted."

Anita: (confused) "What do you mean? I really need to use the bathroom."

(Determined, Anita heads toward the bathroom. Moments later, the camera follows her as she enters a dimly lit stall. She freezes, staring down at the open pit latrine with pure horror on her face. Cut to Anita running back into the hostel, screaming.)

Anita: "Jesus Christ! It's a pit latrine! A pit latrine! How do they expect us to use that?!"

(Chidera bursts into laughter, watching Anita pace in disbelief.)

Chidera: "I told you! No one really uses that. Just buy a potty tomorrow, and you'll be fine."

Anita: (horrified) "A potty? The last time I used one, I was five years old!"

Chidera: "Well, congratulations—you're about to relive your childhood. Welcome to camp!"

(Overwhelmed, Anita grabs her phone and steps outside to avoid the hostel's noise and people seeing her cry. She leans against a tree and dials her father's number, her voice trembling.)

Anita: (crying into the phone) "Daddy, please come and take me! This place is horrible. No proper bathroom, and now they expect me to use a potty!"

(Her parents' faint voices are heard trying to console her as Anita wipes her tears, trying to stay composed. She hangs up and takes a deep breath before walking back inside. Chidera notices her return.)

Chidera: "You'll be fine. Camp is just like that—everybody adjusts."

(Anita sighs heavily and collapses onto her bunk, defeated.)

SCENE 4: Adjusting to Camp Life

1. Waking Up Late and Early Struggles

(The hostel is getting rowdy at 3:30 AM already. Anita is fast asleep on her bunk, her blanket tangled around her. Chidera, already dressed in her white shorts and T-shirt, is moving around the room, preparing for the day. She looks at Anita, sighing.)

Chidera: (loudly whispering) "Anita! Oya, wake up now! Devotion don start soon o, you no wan wake up?"

(Anita stirs, groggily checking the time on her phone.)

Anita: "3:30 AM? What kind of madness is this?"

(She slowly gets up, rubbing her eyes. As she struggles to get dressed, she hears the loud beagle sound from a soldier playing it near the hostel. The noise is loud and piercing, waking everyone nearby. Anita jumps slightly, startled.)

Anita: (panicking) "What was that?!"

Chidera: "That's the beagle sound! Time to wake up, o! Soldier go call us for parade ground now."

(Anita, still groggy, quickly grabs her things, hurrying to get ready. She notices Chidera is already dressed, her white shorts and T-shirt neatly put on. As they head out of the room, Anita feels a little more awake. She glances around, realizing the rest of the camp is starting to wake up too.)

(The loudspeaker crackles again, and the voice of a soldier echoes through the camp.)

Soldier: "All corps members report to the parade ground immediately! Move fast, no time!"

(Anita, still a little disoriented, hesitates but follows Chidera's lead. As they walk toward the parade ground, Anita can feel the nerves rising. Her body feels weak, but she keeps moving forward, unsure of what the day will bring.)

Anita: (muttering to herself) "This is insane. I don't know how I'm going to do this."

(As they approach the parade ground, Anita sees a few other corps members already heading out. The soldiers begin calling everyone to line up. Anita hesitates for a moment as she sees the others moving swiftly into position.)

Soldier: (shouting) "Otondo! You think this is your father's house? Start frog-jumping now!"

(The other corps members start laughing. Anita, embarrassed and unsure of what to do, begins frog-jumping in front of everyone. She stumbles and struggles to keep up with the drill, but she forces herself to continue. Her face flushes with frustration, but she pushes herself harder.)

Background Character 1: (whispering) "She go faint before the week finish!"

(Anita hears the whispers but ignores them, focusing on finishing the punishment. After what feels like forever, she finally stops, exhausted. The soldier looks at her, unimpressed.)

Soldier: "Next time, don't waste my time. You'll do better, Otondo, or I'll have you do it again!"

(Anita nods silently, feeling humiliated but determined to keep going. She walks back to her bunk, physically drained.)

Anita: (muttering) "I'm going to get through this."

2. Avoiding Camp Food

(Later, Anita walks past the mess hall, grimacing as she sees long queues of corps members waiting for their meals—bread and boiled eggs. She turns and walks away, making her way back from the Maimi market, where she bought toast and coffee.)

(As Anita walks back to the hostel sipping her coffee, she spots Aisha standing by a bench. Aisha sees her coming and waves.)

Aisha: (teasing, speaking in Pidgin) "Anita, you no wan chop camp food?"

Anita: (laughing lightly) "Nah, I'm good with my toast."

(Aisha laughs and shakes her head, clearly enjoying teasing Anita.)

(Anita continues walking toward the tree, where she spots Sola and David sitting nearby on the bench. They wave at Anita as she walks up.)

Sola: "Anita, aren't you going to join us for the food?"

David: (laughing) "Omo butty, you'll eat it one day!"

(Anita smiles at them, shaking her head, and walks over to join them under the tree. She sits down with her toast and coffee.)

(Aisha walks over and joins the group under the tree, sitting beside Anita.)

Aisha: (smiling) "You really think you're going to survive without the camp food, eh? At least you've got your toast."

(The group laughs as they sit together, enjoying their break. Anita feels a little more at ease, surrounded by friendly faces and enjoying her meal.)

3. Struggling on the Parade Ground

(The next day, during parade drills, Anita stumbles through the formation. She's out of sync with the others, and the drill sergeant quickly spots her.)

Soldier: "You! Left, right, left! Or are you practicing Azonto here?!"

(Nearby, corps members laugh.)

Background Character 2: (whispering in Pidgin) "E be like say she go faint before the week finish."

(Anita hears them and shakes her head, focusing harder. She's frustrated but determined to improve. After a few more missteps, Aisha notices her struggle and walks over.)

Aisha: "Don't worry, Anita. First week is always the hardest. You'll get the hang of it. Just hang in there!"

(Anita nods, feeling slightly reassured by Aisha's support. She looks at the other corps members and tries her best to stay in line.)

4. Dance Practice

(As part of the platoon's cultural dance group, Anita reluctantly joins in. She's clearly out of sync with the traditional dance moves, stumbling over the steps. Sola and Aisha notice her struggle and offer guidance.)

Sola: "Anita, just follow the beat. Don't think too much!"

Aisha: "You're doing great. No wahala. You'll get it."

(After a few attempts, Anita finally starts to get into the rhythm. By the end of practice, she's smiling, having learned the steps. On the day of the cultural performance, Anita's platoon gets loud cheers. She beams with pride, feeling a sense of achievement.)

5. Debate Competition

(Later, the platoon decides to hold a debate competition, and Sola encourages Anita to participate.)

Sola: "Oya, Anita, this one's for you. I know you're good at arguing!"

Anita: "I'm not doing this!"

Aisha: "Come on, Anita! Just talk about something you care about. You've got this."

(Anita hesitantly agrees. She steps up to deliver her speech during the debate. Anita speaks confidently about youth empowerment and the importance of education. With each word, her confidence grows.)

(By the end of her speech, her platoon wins the first round of the debate. The crowd cheers.)

Background Character 3: "Anita, you carried us today!"

6. Miss NYSC Competition

(The platoon captain approaches Anita with an unexpected request.)

Platoon Captain: "Anita, you're representing us for Miss NYSC."

Anita: "What? Me? No way."

Aisha: (laughing) "You've got this! You're the best fit for it."

(Anita reluctantly agrees and starts preparing for the competition. On the day of the event, she walks the stage with poise and confidence. While she doesn't win the crown, she earns Best Talent for a comedic skit about her struggles during camp.)

Background Character 4: "Anita, you did amazing today!"

(Anita laughs, feeling more confident and proud of herself.)

7. Parade Improvement

(A montage shows Anita improving at marching. She eventually starts staying in sync with her platoon, and soldiers begin nodding approvingly as they notice her progress.)

Soldier: "Good job. Finally, you're marching like a soldier!"

(Anita exchanges a smile with Aisha, Sola, and David, who cheer her on.)

SCENE 5: Three Weeks Later

(Anita steps off the bus at the motor park in Lagos, looking a little tired but much more confident than when she first left. The busy park is filled with people, and she scans the area for her driver, who is supposed to be waiting for her.)

(She spots him standing by the car, holding a sign with her name on it. Anita walks towards him, and he opens the door for her.)

Driver: "Welcome back, madam."

(Anita smiles, feeling a little more at ease. She gets into the car, and as it drives, she looks out the window, reflecting on everything she's been through over the past three weeks.)

(The car pulls up outside her house. Her parents are sitting in the living room, waiting for her return. When Anita walks in, her parents look up, clearly surprised by how much she's changed.)

Father: "So, how was camp?"

Anita: "It was tough, but I'm glad I went. I learned a lot about myself."

Mother: "We're proud of you, Anita. You seem... different."

(Flashbacks show Anita laughing during dance practice, confidently speaking during the debate, and walking the stage during Miss NYSC. Her growth is clear.)

Anita: "I didn't think I'd survive it, but it wasn't so bad after all."

(Her phone buzzes with a text from Aisha: "Miss you already! Hope you didn't forget how to march.")

Anita: (laughing, typing back) "How could I? You made sure of that!"

(The camera pans to a framed photo of Anita and her platoon, taken on the last day of camp. Anita smiles as the scene fades out.)

Closing Text:

"Growth happens outside your comfort zone."